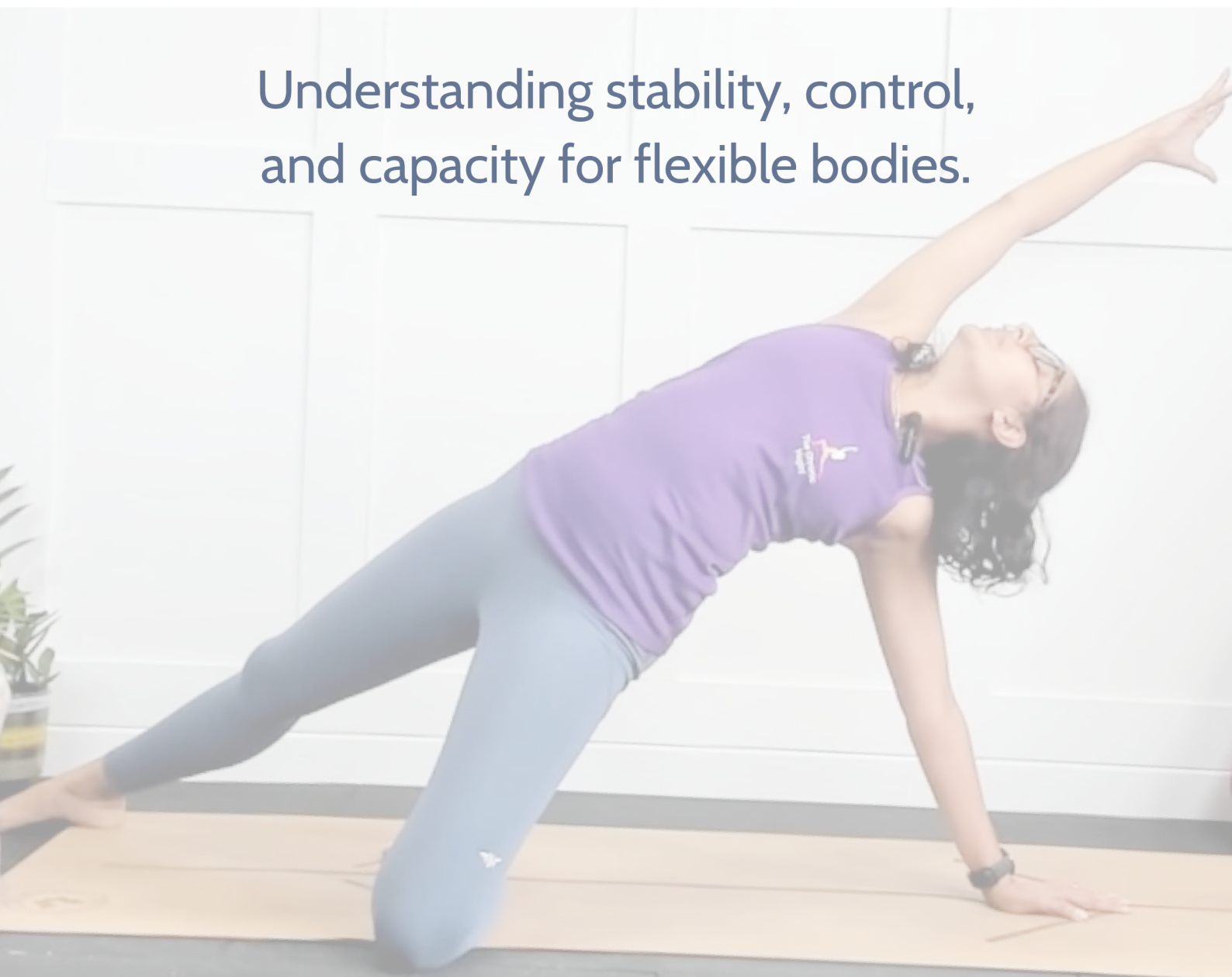




The Chronic Yogini

Why Some Bodies Need Strength Before More Stretching

Understanding stability, control,
and capacity for flexible bodies.



Many people come to yoga or mobility work because they feel tight, restricted, or uncomfortable in their bodies.

Stretching seems like the obvious answer.
And often, it helps.

But for some bodies, particularly those with hypermobility, chronic pain, past injuries, or fluctuating fatigue, stretching more isn't always the missing piece.

Sometimes the body isn't asking for more range.

Sometimes it's asking for more support.

This short guide explores why strength can sometimes matter more than stretching and how understanding this can change the way we approach movement.

The Common Belief

Stretching feels like the solution.

Many people assume that discomfort in the body comes from tightness.

If something feels restricted, the instinct is to stretch it.

This idea is reinforced everywhere:

- yoga classes focused on flexibility
- flexibility routines designed to increase range
- advice to “loosen up” tight areas

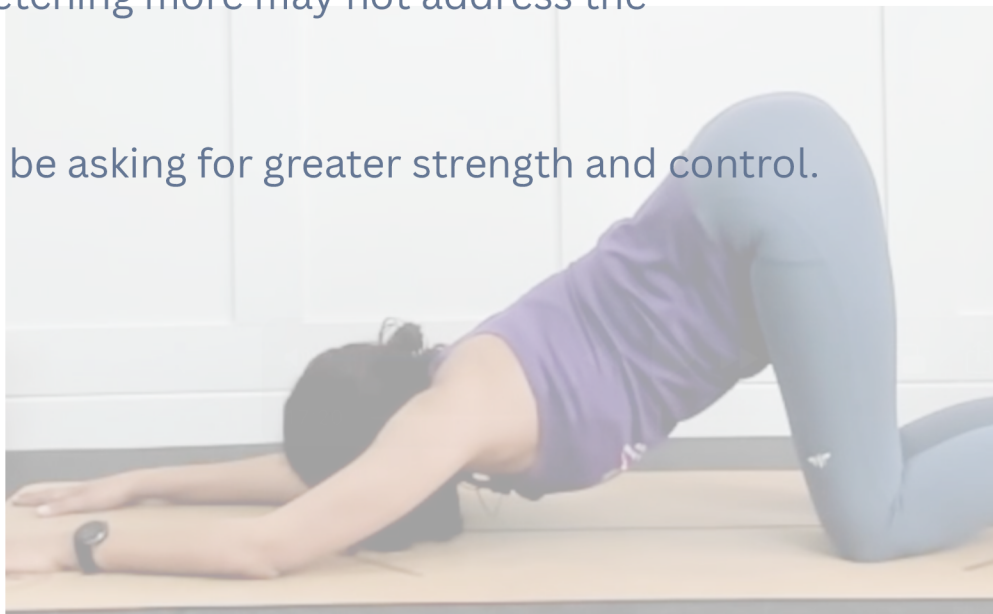
But the body doesn't always experience tightness because something is short.

Sometimes tightness is the body's way of creating stability.

When joints feel unsupported or unstable, the nervous system often responds by increasing muscular tension to protect the area.

In these situations, stretching more may not address the underlying issue.

The body may actually be asking for greater strength and control.



Why Stretching Doesn't Always Help

Range of motion and strength are not the same thing.

A joint can have a large range of motion but still lack the strength to control that range.

This is especially common in people with naturally flexible joints or hypermobility.

In these bodies, stretching further into range can sometimes increase discomfort rather than relieve it.

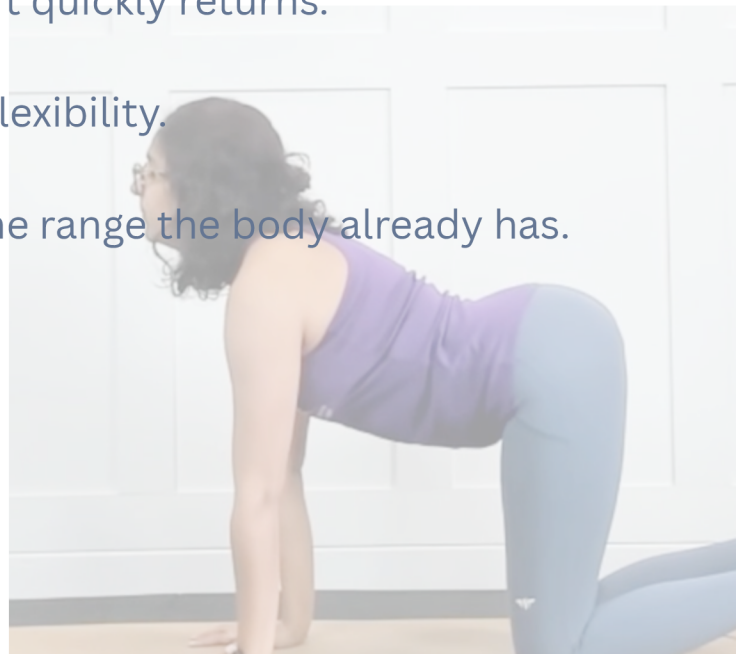
Without sufficient strength, the body may struggle to stabilise the joint during everyday movements.

The nervous system senses this lack of support and may respond by creating tension or protective stiffness.

This is why some people experience a cycle where stretching feels good temporarily, but the discomfort quickly returns.

The issue isn't necessarily a lack of flexibility.

It may be a lack of strength within the range the body already has.



What Strength Changes

Strength creates usable movement.

Strength training doesn't just build muscle.

It improves the body's ability to control movement and support joints.

When muscles develop the capacity to stabilise a joint through a range of motion, the nervous system begins to feel safer allowing movement there.

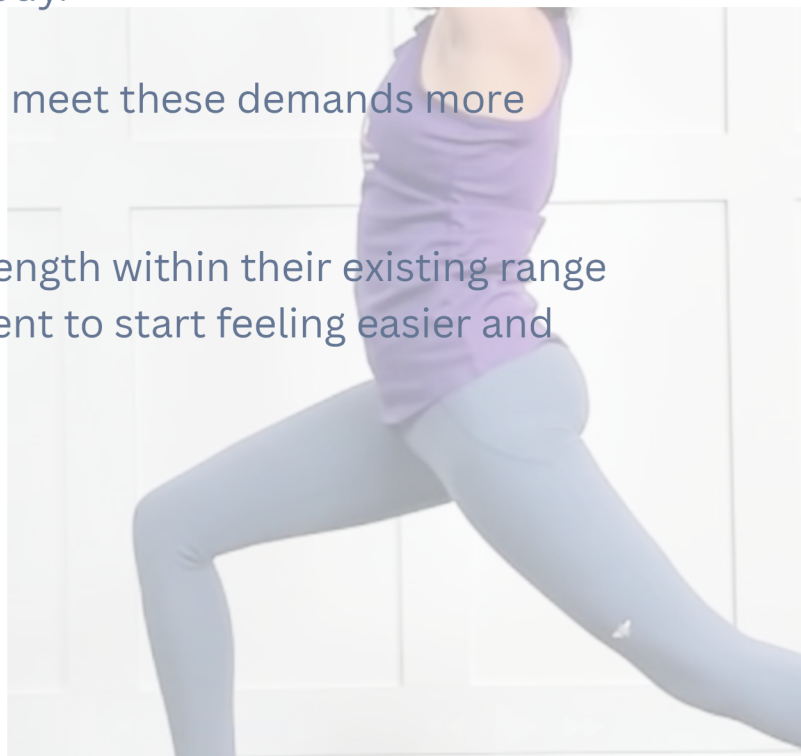
This can reduce protective tension and improve coordination.

Strength also increases tissue capacity: the body's ability to tolerate load during daily life.

Lifting a child, carrying groceries, climbing stairs, or sitting at a desk all place demands on the body.

Building strength helps the body meet these demands more comfortably.

For many people, developing strength within their existing range of motion is what allows movement to start feeling easier and more reliable.



A Different Way to Think About Movement

If stretching has never quite solved the discomfort you feel in your body, it doesn't necessarily mean you are doing it wrong.

It may simply mean your body needs something different.

For some people, the missing piece isn't more flexibility.

It's strength, stability, and the ability to support the movement their body already has.

Learning to recognise this can change the way we approach training and movement practice.

Instead of constantly trying to increase range, the focus becomes building confidence and capacity within the body you have.



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If you enjoy thoughtful conversations about strength, mobility, and complex bodies, I write a monthly newsletter exploring these ideas in more depth.